



WONBIN SSEM · KOREAN

100 Essential Korean Verbs

Real spoken Korean, straight from daily life

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How to Get the Most Out of This Guide

A few notes before you dive in — read these once, then enjoy the verbs.

Real spoken Korean over textbooks

Every example is pulled from real daily conversations. You'll see missing particles (은/는·이/가·을/를) and dropped pronouns — because native speakers almost never say them out loud. Unless you're taking a written exam, getting comfortable with these spoken patterns is the key to sounding natural.

Grammar & cultural insight under every verb

Each verb comes with its everyday **spoken form**, one high-frequency example, and a tip that breaks down the grammar **and** the nuance — the little softeners, the culture, and **when** Koreans actually reach for the expression.

Visualize & immerse

As you read each sentence, picture the exact moment — standing in Korea, saying the words out loud. That mental image makes the phrase stick far better than rote memorization.

Make it yours

Build your own sentences from your routine, your hobbies, the things you say every day. Personalizing these patterns is what turns them from "studied" into "spoken."

Want to dive deeper?

For 1-on-1 feedback, real-time practice, and even more real-life slang — [book a class with me at wonbinssem.com](https://wonbinssem.com).

Let's make you fluently conversational in Korean together. 🙌

가다 to go

SPOKEN 가요 ga-yo

언제 집에 가요?

uhn-je ji-be ga-yo?

When are you going home?

언제 'when' — a question word; up front it turns this into a time question.**-에** 'to home.' -에 marks the destination/direction you're heading to.**가요** In speech, 저 집에 가요 often works as 'I'm heading off now,' like a casual goodbye.

오다 to come

SPOKEN 와요 wa-yo

천천히 와요

chuhn-chuhn-hi wa-yo

Take your time coming.

천천히 'slowly / take your time' — a caring adverb.**와요** 오+아요 contracted. 천천히 와요 means 'no rush, get here safely,' not literally 'walk slow.'

출발하다 to depart

SPOKEN 출발해요 chool-bal-he-yo

출발했어요?

chool-bal-he-ssuh-yo?

Have you left yet?

출발 'departure' (noun); + 하다 makes it a verb.**-았/었어요? (Q)** Past + rising tone. When meeting up, 출발했어요? really means 'are you on your way?'

도착하다 to arrive

SPOKEN 도착해요 do-cha-ke-yo

방금 도착했어요

bang-geum do-cha-ke-ssuh-yo

I just arrived.

방금 'just now' — something that happened a moment ago. 막 도착했어요 works too.**-았/었어요** Past of 도착하다. The perfect text the second you reach the meetup spot.

타다 to ride / to get on

SPOKEN 타요 ta-yo

방금 지하철 탔어요!

bang-geum ji-ha-chuhl ta-ssuh-yo!

I just got on the subway!

지하철(을) 'subway.' Full form is 지하철을 타다, but 을 is usually dropped in speech.**탔어요** 타+았어요 contracted. Also used for elevators (엘리베이터 타다).

내리다 to get off

SPOKEN 내려요 *ne-ryuh-yo*

이제 곧 내려요

i-je got ne-ryuh-yo

I'm getting off soon.

이제 곧 'any second now' — an action that's about to happen.

내려요 Present tense reading as 'about to get off.' Handy on the phone: 저 이제 곧 내려요.

올라가다 to go up

SPOKEN 올라가요 *ol-la-ga-yo*

3층으로 올라가고 있어요

3cheung-eu-ro ol-la-ga-go i-ssuh-yo

I'm going up to the 3rd floor.

3층 'the 3rd floor' — the destination.

(으)로 Direction 'toward.' Use **으로** after a consonant, **로** after a vowel.

-고 있다 Progressive '~ing.' = 'I'm going up right now.'

내려가다 to go down

SPOKEN 내려가요 *ne-ryuh-ga-yo*

제가 내려갈까요?

je-ga ne-ryuh-gal-kka-yo?

Shall I come down?

제가 '저(I)' + subject marker 가.

-(으)ր까요? Offering 'shall I ~?'. Korean centers the speaker, so 내려가다 is used even when moving toward the listener.

들어가다 / 들어오다 to go in / to come in

SPOKEN 들어가요 *deu-ruh-ga-yo*

들어가도 돼요?

deu-ruh-ga-do dwe-yo?

May I go in?

-아/어도 돼요? Asking permission 'may I ~?'. = 'may I go in?'

들어가다 ↔ 들어오다 **들어가다** = go into a space away from you; **들어오다** = come in toward you. Choose by direction, like 가다/오다.

나가다 to go out / to exit

SPOKEN 나가요 *na-ga-yo*

저 이제 나가요

juh i-je na-ga-yo

I'm heading out now.

저 'I' (humble).

이제 'now' — marks a shift; you're about to leave.

나가요 Present tense announces an action starting right this moment.

지나가다 to pass by

SPOKEN 지나가요 ji-na-ga-yo

지나갈게요~

ji-na-gal-ge-yo~

Excuse me, passing through~

-(으)르세요 Speaker's intention 'I'll ~.' THE line for squeezing past people — softer than 비켜요 ('move').

~ (trailing) Stretching the ending keeps it light and friendly, not blunt.

데려다주다 to escort / walk someone

SPOKEN 데려다줘요 de-ryuh-da-jwuh-yo

데려다줘서 고마워요

de-ryuh-da-jwuh-suh go-ma-wuh-yo

Thanks for walking me home.

-아/어서 Reason 'for ~ing.' = 'for walking me (home).'

고마워요 'thank you.' A warm line for someone who saw you home, especially at night.

다니다 to attend / to go regularly

SPOKEN 다녀요 da-nyuh-yo

저 헬스장 다녀요

juh hel-seu-jang da-nyuh-yo

I go to the gym regularly.

헬스장 'gym.' The particle 에 is dropped here (헬스장에 다녀요).

다니다 Use 다니다 for places you go to **regularly** — school, work, gym. 학교 다녀요 = 'I'm a student there.'

여행하다 to travel

SPOKEN 여행해요 yuh-heng-he-yo

여행 많이 해봤어요?

yuh-heng ma-ni he-bwa-ssuh-yo?

Have you traveled a lot?

많이 'a lot' (adverb).

-아/어 봤어요? Experience 'have you ever ~?'. 여행 많이 해봤어요? is a great small-talk opener.

CATEGORY 2 Daily Routine & Life Hygiene

일상 루틴 및 위생

일어나다 to wake up / to get up

SPOKEN 일어나요 i-ruh-na-yo

보통 언제 일어나요?

bo-tong uhn-je i-ruh-na-yo?

When do you usually get up?

보통 'usually' — signals you're asking about a routine.

언제 'when' (question word).

일어나다 Means both 'wake up' and 'stand up' — context decides which.

자다 to sleep

SPOKEN 자요 ja-yo

잘 자요

jal ja-yo

Good night / Sleep well.

잘 'well.' 잘 자요 = sleep well.

자요 To an elder use the honorific 주무세요 (안녕히 주무세요); to a friend, 잘 자.

꿈꾸다 to dream

SPOKEN 꿈꿔요 kkoom-kkwuh-yo

내 꿈꿔요

ne kkoom-kkwuh-yo

Dream of me!

내 'my' (casual). 내 꿈(을) 꾀요 = dream about me.

꿈꾸다 Short for 꿈을 꾸다. A cute, flirty goodnight — sweet, not one for your boss.

눅다 to lie down

SPOKEN 누워요 noo-wuh-yo

집에 가서 빨리 누울 거예요

ji-be ga-suh ppal-li noo-ool guh-ye-yo

I'm going home to lie down right away.

-아/어서 'go, and then ~.' 서 links two actions in order.

빨리 'quickly / right away.'

-(으)르 거예요 Future 'will ~.' 눅다 is ㅂ **irregular** → 누워요, 누울.

앉다 to sit

SPOKEN 앉아요 an-ja-yo

여기 앉아도 돼요?

yuh-gi an-ja-do dwe-yo?

May I sit here?

여기 'here.'

-아/어도 돼요? Permission 'may I ~?'. 앉아도 될까요? is even more polite.

쉬다 to rest

SPOKEN 쉬어요 swi-uh-yo

빨리 쉬어요

ppal-li swi-uh-yo

Get some rest.

빨리 'quickly' — here more like 'go on, get some rest.'

쉬어요 A caring line. 꼭 쉬어요 ('rest deeply') is warmer still.

씻다 to wash (oneself)

SPOKEN 씻어요 ssi-suh-yo

먼저 씻어요

muhn-juh ssi-suh-yo

You wash up first.

먼저 'first / go ahead.'

씻다 General 'wash up' (face, hands, shower). Regular — stays 씻어요.

샤워하다 to take a shower

SPOKEN 샤워해요 shyu-wuh-he-yo

아침에 샤워해요

a-chi-me shyu-wuh-he-yo

I shower in the morning.

-에 'in the morning.' -에 marks a point in time.

샤워해요 Loanword 샤워 + 하다. Present tense states a habit.

양치하다 to brush teeth

SPOKEN 양치해요 yang-chi-he-yo

한국인은 밖에서도 자주 양치해요

han-goo-gi-neun ba-kke-suh-do ja-joo yang-chi-he-yo

Koreans often brush their teeth even when out.

-에서도 'even outside/out and about.' 에서 (at) + 도 (even).

자주 'often.'

양치해요 Culture: many carry a toothbrush to brush after lunch at work — dental hygiene is a big deal.

장보다 to buy groceries

SPOKEN 장봐요 jang-bwa-yo

오늘 장봤어요

o-neul jang-bwa-ssuh-yo

I went grocery shopping today.

오늘 'today.'

장보다 장 + 보다, past 봤어요. = the food shop at a market/mart — more routine than casual 쇼핑.

청소하다 to clean

SPOKEN 청소해요 chuhng-so-he-yo

오늘 방 청소했어요

o-neul bang chuhng-so-he-ssuh-yo

I cleaned my room today.

방(을) 'room' (object; 을 dropped in speech).

-았/었어요 Past. 대청소 = a big deep-clean (like spring cleaning).

빨래하다 to do laundry

SPOKEN 빨래해요 *ppal-le-he-yo*

집에 가서 빨래해야 해요

ji-be ga-suh ppal-le-he-ya he-yo

I have to do laundry when I get home.

-아/어서 'go home, and then ~' (sequence).

-아/어야 하다 Obligation 'have to ~.' 빨래 = both the task and the clothes.

살다 to live

SPOKEN 살아요 *sa-ra-yo*

홍대 근처에 살아요

hong-de geun-chuh-e sa-ra-yo

I live near Hongdae.

-에 'near ~.' -에 marks the location here.

살다 ㄹ **irregular** (ㄹ drops: 삽니다, 사세요). The standard reply to 어디 살아요?

이다 to be (identity)

SPOKEN 이에요 / 예요 *i-e-yo / ye-yo*

저는 학생이에요

juh-neun hak-sseng-i-e-yo

I'm a student.

-는 'as for me' — the topic marker.

이에요/예요 The copula 'to be.' **이에요** after a consonant (학생이에요), **예요** after a vowel (의사예요).

CATEGORY 3 Dining & Cooking

식사 및 요리

먹다 to eat

SPOKEN 먹어요 *muh-guh-yo*

밥 먹었어요?

bap muh-guh-ssuh-yo?

Have you eaten?

밥(을) 'rice / a meal.' The object marker 을 is dropped in speech.

-았/었어요? (Q) Culture: 밥 먹었어요? is a daily greeting like 'how are you?' — it signals care. To an elder: 식사하셨어요?

마시다 to drink

SPOKEN 마셔요 *ma-shyuh-yo*

커피 마셨어요

kuh-pi ma-shyuh-ssuh-yo

I drank coffee.

커피(를) 'coffee' (object; 를 dropped).

마셨어요 마시+었어요 → 마셨어요. Bonus: 한잔하다 = grab a (usually alcoholic) drink.

요리하다 to cook

SPOKEN 요리해요 *yo-ri-he-yo*

평소에 요리해요?

pyuhng-so-e yo-ri-he-yo?

Do you usually cook?

평소에 'usually / normally.' It asks about a habit.

요리해요 Full form 요리(를) 하다. Rising tone makes it a question.

설거지하다 to wash dishes

SPOKEN 설거지해요 *suhl-guh-ji-he-yo*

설거지 하기 싫어요

suhl-guh-ji ha-gi shi-ruh-yo

I don't want to do the dishes.

설거지 'the dishes' — the chore nobody wants (pairs with 귀찮아요, 'what a hassle').

-기 싫다 Nominalizer 기 + 싫다 = 'hate/don't want to do ~.'

만들다 to make

SPOKEN 만들어요 *man-deu-ruh-yo*

이거 제가 만들었어요

i-guh je-ga man-deu-ruh-ssuh-yo

I made this myself.

이거(를) 'this' (object; 를 dropped).

제가 'I' + subject marker 가 — adds a little note of pride.

만들다 Past 만들었어요. (ㄹ verb: 만드니까, 만드세요.)

CATEGORY 4 Clothing & Accessories

의복 및 착용

입다 to wear (clothes)

SPOKEN 입어요 *i-buh-yo*

추워서 옷 많이 입었어요

choo-wuh-suh ot ma-ni i-buh-ssuh-yo

I bundled up because it was cold.

-아/어서 Reason 'because it's cold' (춥다 → 추워요, ㅂ irregular).

많이 'a lot / heavily.'

입다 For garments on the body. Each clothing type has its OWN verb — that's this section's theme.

벗다 to take off

SPOKEN 벗어요 buh-suh-yo

너무 더워서 벗을 거예요

nuh-moo duh-wuh-suh buh-seul guh-ye-yo

I'll take it off, it's too hot.

-아/어서 Reason 'because it's hot' (덥다 → 더워요).

-(으)ㄹ 거예요 Future 'will ~.' Culture: taking off your shoes (신발 벗다) before entering a home is a must.

쓰다 (2) to wear (hat / glasses)

SPOKEN 써요 ssuh-yo

원래 안경 썼어요

wuhl-le an-gyuhng ssuh-ssuh-yo

I used to wear glasses.

원래 'originally / used to.'

안경(을) 'glasses' (object; 을 dropped).

쓰다 — **irregular** (쓰 → 써). Only for things worn on the head/face (hats, glasses, masks).

끼다 to wear (rings / gloves / lenses)

SPOKEN 끼요 kkyuh-yo

그때는 렌즈 끼었어요

geu-tte-neun ren-jeu kkyuh-ssuh-yo

Back then I wore contacts.

-는 'back then' (as for that time — topic marker).

렌즈(를) 'contact lenses' (object).

끼다 끼+었어요 → 끼었어요. For items that fit snugly — rings, gloves, contacts.

CATEGORY 5 Communication & Relationships

소통 및 인간관계

말하다 to speak / to say

SPOKEN 말해요 mal-he-yo

천천히 말해 주세요

chuhn-chuhn-hi mal-he joo-se-yo

Please speak slowly.

천천히 'slowly.'

-아/어 주세요 Favor 'please do (it) for me.' The #1 survival phrase. Add 다시 한번 for 'once more.'

이야기하다 to talk / to chat

SPOKEN 이야기해요 i-ya-gi-he-yo

내일 이야기해요

ne-il i-ya-gi-he-yo

Let's talk tomorrow.

내일 'tomorrow.'

이야기해요 Usually shortened to 얘기해요 in speech. Present here = a soft 'let's ~.'

물어보다 to ask (a question)

SPOKEN 물어봐요 moo-ruh-bwa-yo

뭐 좀 물어봐도 돼요?

mwuh jom moo-ruh-bwa-do dwe-yo?

Can I ask you something?

뭐 좀 'something.' Adding **좀** keeps the ask casual and low-pressure — gentler than a blunt 질문 있어요.

-아/어도 돼요? 묻다 → 물어 (ㄷ irregular) + 보다 + permission. Sprinkle **좀** to sound polite: 이거 좀 주세요, 좀 도와주세요.

대답하다 to answer

SPOKEN 대답해요 de-da-pe-yo

천천히 대답해도 괜찮아요

chuhn-chuhn-hi de-da-pe-do gwen-cha-na-yo

Take your time answering.

천천히 'slowly / take your time.'

-아/어도 괜찮다 Reassurance 'it's OK to ~.' 괜찮아요 lowers the pressure when someone's put on the spot.

전화하다 to call (on a phone)

SPOKEN 전화해요 juhn-hwa-he-yo

일 끝나고 전화할게요

il kkeun-na-go juhn-hwa-hal-ge-yo

I'll call after work.

-고 'after ~ ends.' 고 links two events in order (work ends, then I call).

-(으)ր게요 Promise 'I'll call.' 통화하다 = to be on a call.

보내다 to send

SPOKEN 보내요 bo-ne-yo

늦게 보내서 미안해요

neut-kke bo-ne-suh mi-an-he-yo

Sorry for sending this late.

늦게 'late' (adverb; 늦다 + 게).

-아/어서 Reason 'for ~ing.' 보내서 미안해요 = 'sorry for sending.' A texting staple.

소개하다 to introduce

SPOKEN 소개해요 so-ge-he-yo

친구가 소개해 줬어요

chin-goo-ga so-ge-he jwuh-ssuh-yo

A friend introduced us.

-가 'a friend' (subject marker).

-아/어 주다 + 주다 (did a favor), past 줬어요. Culture: 소개팅 = a set-up blind date.

약속하다 to promise / to make plans

SPOKEN 약속해요 yak-ssso-ke-yo

진짜요? 약속해요

jin-jja-jyo? yak-ssso-ke-yo

For real? Promise.

-죠? A tag question 'right?' that fishes for agreement.

약속 약속 = both 'a promise' AND 'plans' — 오늘 약속 있어요 = 'I have plans.'

주다 to give

SPOKEN 줘요 jwuh-yo

제 친구가 줬어요

je chin-goo-ga jwuh-ssuh-yo

My friend gave it to me.

-가 'my friend' (subject marker).

주다 주+었어요 → 줬어요. As a helper ~아/어 주다 = 'do for someone.' Giving TO an elder uses humble 드리다.

받다 to receive

SPOKEN 받아요 ba-da-yo

이거 어디서 받았어요?

i-guh uh-di-suh ba-da-ssuh-yo?

Where did you get this?

-에서 'where from.' 어디서 = 어디에서 (source/location).

-았/었어요? (Q) Past. For gifts, items, even calls (전화 받다 = 'answer the phone').

도와주다 to help

SPOKEN 도와줘요 do-wa-jwuh-yo

도와줄 수 있어요?

do-wa-jool soo i-ssuh-yo?

Can you help me?

-(으)ㄴ 수 있다 돕다 → 도와 (ㅂ irregular) + 주다 + ability 'can you ~?'

좀 (tip) Add 좀 — 좀 도와줄 수 있어요? — to sound warmer and less demanding.

부탁하다 to ask a favor

SPOKEN 부탁해요 boo-ta-ke-yo

이거 좀 부탁드릴게요

i-guh jom boo-tak-tteu-ril-ge-yo

Could you handle this for me?

좀 'a little' — softens the request so it isn't pushy.

부탁드리다 Humble 드리다 + ~(으)르게요. Everywhere in Korean work life. 잘 부탁드립니다 = 'looking forward to working with you.'

믿다 to believe / to trust

SPOKEN 믿어요 mi-duh-yo

저 믿어도 돼요

juh mi-duh-do dwe-yo

You can trust me.

저 'me' (object; 를 dropped).

-아/어도 되다 Here it reassures: 'you can trust me.' 믿어 봐요 = 'just give it a try / trust me.'

만나다 to meet

SPOKEN 만나요 man-na-yo

얼른 만나요

uhl-leun man-na-yo

Let's meet up soon!

얼른 'quickly / soon, without delay.'

만나요 Present as a friendly proposal 'let's meet.' 만나서 반가워요 = 'nice to meet you.'

CATEGORY 6 Work, Study & Practice

업무, 학업 및 연습

하다 to do

SPOKEN 해요 he-yo

오늘 뭐 해요?

o-neul mwuh he-yo?

What are you up to today?

오늘 'today.'

뭐 'what' (object question word).

하다 하+여요 → 해요. 뭐 해요? doubles as a casual 'what's up?'

일하다 to work

SPOKEN 일해요 *il-he-yo*

어제 하루 종일 일했어요

uh-je ha-roo jong-il il-he-ssuh-yo

I worked all day yesterday.

어제 'yesterday.'

하루 종일 'all day long.'

일했어요 Past. 야근하다 = to work overtime — a very Korean reality.

공부하다 to study

SPOKEN 공부해요 *gong-boo-he-yo*

한국어 열심히 공부했어요

han-goo-guh yuhl-shim-hi gong-boo-he-ssuh-yo

I studied Korean hard.

한국어(를) 'Korean (language)' (object; 를 dropped).

열심히 'hard / diligently' — sits right before the verb; you'll hear it constantly.

공부했어요 Past of 공부하다.

배우다 to learn

SPOKEN 배워요 *be-wuh-yo*

원빈쌤한테 많이 배워요

wuhn-bin-ssem-han-te ma-ni be-wuh-yo

I learn a lot from Wonbin Ssem!

-한테 'from (a person).' Marks who you learn from.

많이 'a lot.'

배워요 배우+어요 → 배워요. The natural partner of 가르치다 (teach).

가르치다 to teach

SPOKEN 가르쳐요 *ga-reu-chyuh-yo*

원빈쌤 한국어 진짜 잘 가르쳐요

wuhn-bin-ssem han-goo-guh jin-jja jal ga-reu-chyuh-yo

Wonbin Ssem teaches Korean really well!

진짜 잘 'really well.'

가르치다 가르치+어요 → 가르쳐요. Don't mix up with 가리키다 ('point at').

읽다 to read

SPOKEN 읽어요 *il-guh-yo*

한국어 읽을 수는 있어요

han-goo-guh il-geul soo-neun i-ssuh-yo

I can at least read Korean.

-(으)를 수는 있다 'can read.' The 는 in 수는 adds 'at least' — 'I can read it, even if not fully understand.'

받침 ㄹ 읽어요 is said **[일거요]** — the ㄹ links over to the next syllable.

쓰다 (3) to write

SPOKEN 써요 ssuh-yo

매일 일기 써요

me-il il-gi ssuh-yo

I write a diary every day.

매일 'every day.'

일기(를) 'diary' (object). 일기(를) 쓰다 = keep a diary.

쓰다 — **irregular** (쓰 → 써). Same 쓰다 also means 'use' and 'wear (glasses).'

연습하다 to practice

SPOKEN 연습해요 yuhn-seu-pe-yo

많이 연습해야 해요

ma-ni yuhn-seu-pe-ya he-yo

I have to practice a lot.

많이 'a lot.'

-아/어야 하다 Obligation 'have to ~.' 연습 = practice; 실전 = the real thing.

복습하다 to review

SPOKEN 복습해요 bok-sseu-pe-yo

수업 끝나고 꼭 복습할게요

soo-uhp kkeun-na-go kkok bok-sseu-pal-ge-yo

I'll definitely review after class.

-고 'after (class) ends.'

꼭 'for sure / without fail.'

-(으)ր게요 Promise. 복습 = review after; 예습 = pre-study before.

준비하다 to prepare

SPOKEN 준비해요 joon-bi-he-yo

열심히 준비해야 해요

yuhl-shim-hi joon-bi-he-ya he-yo

I need to prepare hard.

열심히 'hard / diligently.'

-아/어야 하다 Necessity 'need to ~.' 준비됐어요? = 'ready?'

시작하다 to start

SPOKEN 시작해요 shi-ja-ke-yo

이제 막 시작했어요

i-je mak shi-ja-ke-ssuh-yo

I just started.

이제 막 'just this moment.'

시작했어요 Past. 시작이 반이다 = 'starting is half the battle' — a beloved saying.

끝나다 to end / to finish

SPOKEN 끝나요 kkeun-na-yo

언제 끝나요?

uhn-je kkeun-na-yo?

When does it finish?

언제 'when.'

끝나다 **Intransitive** — it ends by itself (수업이 끝나요). To say 'I finish X,' use transitive 끝내다.

CATEGORY 7 Cognition, Thought & Memory

인지, 생각 및 기억

알다 to know

SPOKEN 알아요 a-ra-yo

여기 알아요?

yuh-gi a-ra-yo?

Do you know this place?

여기(를) 'this place' (여기(를) 알다).

알다 **르 irregular** (압니다, 아세요, 아는). 알겠어요 = 'got it / understood.'

모르다 to not know

SPOKEN 몰라요 mol-la-yo

잘 몰라요

jal mol-la-yo

I don't really know.

잘 'well' — 잘 몰라요 softens to 'I'm not too sure,' gentler than a flat 몰라요.

모르다 **르 irregular** (르 → 르르: 몰라요).

생각하다 to think

SPOKEN 생각해요 seng-ga-ke-yo

생각해 볼게요

seng-ga-ke bol-ge-yo

I'll think about it.

-아/어 보다 + -(으)르게요 'I'll think about it.' Often a polite soft-decline ('let me consider' = probably not) — read the room.

기억하다 to remember

SPOKEN 기억해요 gi-uh-ke-yo

아직도 기억해요?

a-jik-tto gi-uh-ke-yo?

You still remember?

아직도 'still, even now' — often with pleasant surprise.

기억하다 Opposite: 잊어버리다 (to forget).

쓰다 (1) to use

SPOKEN 써요 ssuh-yo

저는 아이폰 써요

juh-neun a-i-pon ssuh-yo

I use an iPhone.

-는 'as for me' (topic marker).

아이폰(을) 'iPhone' (object; 을 dropped).

쓰다 — **irregular** (쓰 → 써). Everyday 'use' for devices; 사용하다 is the formal twin.

켜다 to turn on

SPOKEN 켜요 kyuh-yo

노트북 켜고 있어요

no-teu-book kyuh-go i-ssuh-yo

I'm booting up my laptop.

노트북(을) 'laptop' (object).

-고 있다 Progressive 'in the middle of turning on.' In casual speech 켜다 is often said [키다] (불 키다).

끄다 to turn off

SPOKEN 꺼요 kkuh-yo

배터리 다 돼서 꺼졌어요

be-tuh-ri da dwe-suh kkuh-jyuh-ssuh-yo

It died because the battery ran out.

-아/어서 'because it ran out.' 배터리가 다 되다 = the battery died.

꺼지다 끄다 → change-of-state 꺼지다 ('got turned off'). (— irregular.)

멈추다 to stop / to freeze

SPOKEN 멈춰요 muhm-chwuh-yo

휴대폰 갑자기 멈췄어요

hyoo-de-pon gap-jja-gi muhm-chwuh-ssuh-yo

My phone suddenly froze.

갑자기 'suddenly.'

멈추다 멈추+었어요 → 멈췄어요. For moving objects or frozen apps/devices.

열다 to open

SPOKEN 열어요 yuh-ruh-yo

지금 문 열었어요?

ji-geum moon yuh-ruh-ssuh-yo?

Are you open now?

지금 'now.'

열다 ㄹ **irregular**. Literally 'open the door,' but also 'are you open for business?' — great for checking store hours.

닫다 to close

SPOKEN 닫아요 da-da-yo

여기 언제 닫아요?

yuh-gi uhn-je da-da-yo?

What time do you close?

언제 'when / what time.'

닫다 For doors, windows, and business hours. 오늘 문 닫았어요 = 'closed for the day.'

CATEGORY 9 Exercise & Physical Movement

운동 및 신체 활동

운동하다 to exercise / to work out

SPOKEN 운동해요 oon-dong-he-yo

요즘은 운동 안 해요

yo-jeu-meun oon-dong an he-yo

I'm not working out these days.

-은/는 'these days' (as for lately — topic marker).

안 (negation) In 하다-verbs, 안 splits IN: 운동 안 해요 (never 안 운동해요).

걷다 to walk

SPOKEN 걸어요 guh-ruh-yo

어제 진짜 많이 걸었어요

uh-je jin-jja ma-ni guh-ruh-ssuh-yo

I walked so much yesterday.

진짜 많이 'really a lot.'

걷다 ㄷ irregular (걸 → 걸어). 걸어서 가다 = 'go on foot.' Don't confuse with 걸다 ('hang / call').

운전하다 to drive

SPOKEN 운전해요 oon-juhn-he-yo

여기 사람들 무섭게 운전해요

yuh-gi sa-ram-deul moo-suhp-kke oon-juhn-he-yo

People here drive scary.

-게 'scarily.' Adjective 무섭다 + 게 → adverb. This ~게 turns adjectives into adverbs (예쁘게, 크게).

운전해요 운전(을) 하다 — the object 을 is dropped.

노래하다 to sing

SPOKEN 노래해요 no-re-he-yo

와 노래 진짜 잘해요

wa no-re jin-jja jal-he-yo

Wow, you sing really well!

와 'wow.'

잘하다 'really good at it' — a genuine compliment. 노래방 (karaoke room) is core to a night out.

춤을 추다 to dance

SPOKEN 춤을 춥쇼 choo-meul chwuh-yo

저 춤 조금 춥쇼

juh choom jo-geum chwuh-yo

I dance a little.

조금 'a little' — modest downplaying (Koreans often do this even when good).

추다 추+어요 → 춥쇼.

CATEGORY 10 Possession, Existence & Shopping

소유, 존재 및 쇼핑

있다 to have / to exist

SPOKEN 있어요 i-ssuh-yo

남자/여자친구 있어요?

nam-ja/yuh-ja-chin-goo i-ssuh-yo?

Do you have a boyfriend/girlfriend?

남자/여자친구 'boyfriend/girlfriend' (object).

있다 Covers existence AND possession. A classic ice-breaker. Also builds 재미있다, 맛있다.

없다 to not have / to not exist

SPOKEN 없어요 uhp-suh-yo

돈 없어요

don uhp-suh-yo

I'm broke.

돈(이) 'money' (subject; 이 dropped).

없다 Opposite of 있다 (NOT 안 있다). 시간 없어요 / 관심 없어요 are everyday uses.

사다 to buy

SPOKEN 사요 sa-yo

한국에서 많이 샀어요

han-goo-ge-suh ma-ni sa-ssuh-yo

I bought a lot in Korea.

-에서 'in Korea.' -에서 marks where an action happens.

사다 사+았어요 → 샀어요. 사 주다 = 'buy it for someone' (제가 사 줄게요 = 'my treat').

필요하다 to need

SPOKEN 필요해요 pi-ryo-he-yo

이거 진짜 필요했어요

i-guh jin-jja pi-ryo-he-ssuh-yo

I really needed this!

이거(가) 'this' — but watch the particle below.

이가 필요하다 Takes the subject marker 이/가 (이게 필요해요), NOT 을/를 — a very common learner slip.

좋아하다 to like

SPOKEN 좋아해요 jo-a-he-yo

저 그거 진짜 좋아해요!

juh geu-guh jin-jja jo-a-he-yo!

I really like that!

을/를 'that' (object). Transitive — it takes 을/를 (그거를 좋아해요).

진짜 'really' (intensifier).

좋아하다 vs 좋다 좋아하다 = 'to like' (an action); the adjective 좋다 = 'to be good/nice.'

싫어하다 to dislike / to hate

SPOKEN 싫어해요 shi-ruh-he-yo

음 저 가지 진짜 싫어해요

euk juh ga-ji jin-jja shi-ruh-he-yo

Ew, I really hate eggplant.

음 'ugh / ew' — a spoken sound effect that adds real flavor.

가지 'eggplant' (object).

싫어하다 vs 싫다 The action verb 'dislike'; the adjective 싫다 = 'to be unpleasant.'

사랑하다 to love

SPOKEN 사랑해요 sa-rang-he-yo

많이 사랑해요

ma-ni sa-rang-he-yo

I love you so much.

많이 Literally 'a lot' → 'so much' here.

사랑해요 사랑해 (casual) between couples; 사랑해요 is warmer/polite. For a lighter 'I like you,' use 좋아해요.

웃다 to laugh / to smile

SPOKEN 웃어요 oo-suh-yo

웃는 모습이 예뻐요

oon-neun mo-seu-bi ye-ppuh-yo

Your smile is lovely.

V+는 'smiling.' V+는 modifies the noun that follows. 웃는 모습 = 'the way you smile.'

-이 'look/appearance' (subject).

예뻐요 'is lovely.' Bonus: 웃기다 = 'to be funny / make someone laugh.'

울다 to cry

SPOKEN 울어요 oo-ruh-yo

울지 마요..

ool-ji ma-yo..

Don't cry..

-지 마요/마세요 Prohibition 'don't ~.' A gentle comfort line; casual: 울지 마. (울다 is ㄹ irregular.)

걱정하다 to worry

SPOKEN 걱정해요 guhk-jjuhng-he-yo

걱정 마세요

guhk-jjuhng ma-se-yo

Don't worry.

걱정 마세요 The clipped everyday form of 걱정하지 마세요 — the short one is more natural in speech. 걱정되다 = 'to feel worried.'

느끼다 to feel

SPOKEN 느껴요 neu-kkyuh-yo

저도 느꼈어요!

juh-do neu-kkyuh-ssuh-yo!

I felt that too!

-도 'me too.' -도 = 'also / too.'

느끼다 느끼+었어요 → 느꼈어요. The noun 느낌 ('feeling/vibe') is used constantly: 느낌 좋아요.

CATEGORY 12 Social Life & Life Events

사회 생활 및 삶의 사건

놀다 to hang out / to play

SPOKEN 놀아요 no-ra-yo

우리 주말에 같이 놀아요!

oo-ri joo-ma-re ga-ti no-ra-yo!

Let's hang out this weekend!

-에 'on the weekend.' -에 marks a time.

같이 'together.' (Said [가치].)

놀다 ㄹ **irregular**. For adults, 놀다 = 'hang out,' not childish play. 놀러 가다 = 'go hang out.'

기다리다 to wait

SPOKEN 기다려요 gi-da-ryuh-yo

조금만 기다려 주세요

jo-geum-man gi-da-ryuh joo-se-yo

Just a moment, please.

-만 'just a little.' -만 = 'only / just.'

-아/어 주세요 Favor 'please ~ for me.' 잠깐만요 ('one sec') is its casual cousin.

결혼하다 to get married

SPOKEN 결혼해요 gyuhl-hon-he-yo

저 한국인이랑 결혼했어요

juh han-goo-gi-ni-rang gyuhl-hon-he-ssuh-yo

I married a Korean.

-이랑/랑 'with a Korean.' The partner takes -이랑/랑 or -와/과 ('with').

결혼했어요 Past. 결혼 = marriage; 청혼 / 프러포즈 = a proposal.

축하하다 to congratulate

SPOKEN 축하해요 choo-ka-he-yo

합격 축하해요!

hap-kkyuhk choo-ka-he-yo!

Congrats on passing!

합격 'passing (an exam/interview)' — the thing you're congratulating.

축하해요 Swap in 생일 (birthday), 졸업 (graduation), etc. 축하드려요 is the politer version.

되다 to become / to end up

SPOKEN 돼요 dwe-yo

그렇게 한국어 공부하게 됐어요

geu-ruh-ke han-goo-guh gong-boo-ha-ge dwe-ssuh-yo

That's how I ended up studying Korean.

그렇게 'that's how / like that' — sums up the backstory.

-게 되다 'ended up ~ing' — a result shaped by circumstances. Spelling: 됐어요, NOT 뒀어요.

태어나다 to be born

SPOKEN 태어나요 te-uh-na-yo

작년에 제 조카가 태어났어요

jang-nyuh-ne je jo-ka-ga te-uh-na-ssuh-yo

My niece was born last year.

-에 'last year.'

-가 'niece/nephew' (no gender split) + subject marker.

태어나다 Past. Intransitive — someone is born.

죽다 to die

SPOKEN 죽어요 joo-guh-yo

더워 죽을 것 같아요

duh-wuh joo-geul guht ga-ta-yo

I'm dying of heat!

-아/어 죽을 것 같다 Hyperbole! Koreans exaggerate feelings this way — 배고파 죽겠어요 (starving), 힘들어 죽겠어요. Rarely literal.

이기다 to win

SPOKEN 이겨요 *i-gyuh-yo*

이번엔 제가 꼭 이길 거예요

i-buh-nen je-ga kkok i-gil guh-ye-yo

I'll definitely win this time!

-엔 'this time.' 이번에는 → 이번엔.

꼭 'for sure / definitely.'

-(으)ㄹ 거예요 Future 'will win.' 이기+어요 → 이겨요. Opposite: 지다.

지다 to lose (a game)

SPOKEN 져요 *jyuh-yo*

질 수도 있죠

jil soo-do it-jjyo

We might lose — it happens.

-(으)ㄹ 수도 있다 Possibility 'might ~.' + 죠 adds a relaxed, accepting shrug ('that's how it goes'). 지+어요 → 져요.

이사 가다 / 이사하다 to move house

SPOKEN 이사 가요 *i-sa ga-yo*

다음 달에 이사 가요

da-eum da-re i-sa ga-yo

I'm moving next month.

-에 'next month.'

이사 가다 Present states a fixed near-future plan. Culture: 집들이 = a housewarming party.